SPEAKER ONE-SHEET

Dan Mercede

Operator first, then builder. AI workflows with clear ownership, from the first working version to the checks that keep them running.

BIO

Dan Mercede spent four years as a General Manager with full P&L ownership, and fifteen years before that in sales and financial operations: representing Apple as a field sales rep with Mosaic Sales Solutions, field sales at Diageo, and financial analysis at Nestlé USA. Running a business showed him where automation breaks: nobody owns the workflow, so nobody notices when it drifts.

He now builds AI systems around that problem. He operates a private AI control plane that has run continuously for months on a self-managed cluster, and publishes the reusable parts as open-source tools, including failclosed, schemafit, and mcp-context-budget.

UPCOMING

OpsWorld 2027 · February 9, 2027

Close Incidents With Solution Docs and Check Runbook Freshness

50-minute hands-on workshop in Santa Clara, CA, co-located with DeveloperWeek 2027

PAST SPEAKING

NODES 2026 by Neo4j · November 12, 2026

Don't Flatten the Tree: Ingesting Branched Conversations into a Knowledge Graph

Speaker page: https://neo4j.com/nodes/speakers/dan-mercede/

RECOGNITION

Finalist, UiPath AgentHack 2026 (Track 3, UiPath Test Cloud), for Proctor, behavioral regression testing for AI agents.

TALKS

- **Who owns the workflow?**
  Why AI pilots stall after a good demo, and five tests that separate a demo from a workflow a business can depend on.
- **Fail closed by default**
  Merge admission for AI-written code: distrust the reviewer's output, refuse to merge on anything ambiguous, and prove the gate fires.
- **Don't flatten the tree**
  Ingesting branched LLM conversation history into a production knowledge graph without losing branch identity.
- **Agents inside a context budget**
  Keeping tool surfaces and web access from eating a coding agent's context window.

FORMATS

Conference talks, meetups, podcasts, and virtual sessions. Screen-share demos of running systems where the format allows.

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